was heavily engaged in conflict with the MNDAA in their region. That demand cast doubt on the feasibility of signing a ceasefire agreement prior to political dialogue (Radio Free Asia 2015). Therefore, continuation of the peace process depended heavily on whether the peace technical team could encourage the Tatmadaw and the EAGs to continue with peace talks despite disputes. The next section explains how the approach of the MPC helped sustain the peace process to the end of 2015.

A PIECEMEAL APPROACH

This section examines the second part of my argument: that the MPC as the centre of the peace policy community employed a piecemeal approach in dealing with the Tatmadaw and EAGs. This piecemeal approach allowed the Tatmadaw and the EAGs to affirm their commitments incrementally, and to adhere to the peace process. The question of whether such a piecemeal approach influenced the decisions of the Tatmadaw and the ethnic leaders in committing to the process is analysed from two perspectives: (i) formal binding; and (ii) informal binding.

Formal binding

Binding decisions formally offer assurance to policy actors. These formal bindings are legitimate products of the negotiations made either through the inclusion and (possible) participation of the full set of legitimate decision-makers, or by recourse to a formally restricted area. As Christiansen and Neuhold (2012) highlight, negotiations made outside formal settings are crucial, but they require legitimation through formalization. The decision-makers' formal commitments represent their positions as authorities of organizations.

In the Myanmar ethnic peace process, formal binding was crucial. It made the MPC's piecemeal actions legitimate through authoritative guarantees established by policy actors representing their institutions, and encouraged the Tatmadaw and the EAGs to remain attached to peace talks despite constraints. The peace policy's federal vision is an instance of how formal binding worked through the MPC's piecemeal approach.

The federal vision as formally binding: One of the principal demands of